Introduction

If you grew up in the 1990s in a middle-class Hindu family in southern Bharat, not to perpetuate stereotypes, but chances are that a career in engineering or medicine featured right at the top of your life goals. My goals were no different, not just because of my limited means and exposure but also because I was keen on pursuing a career in aerospace engineering. However, eventually, I had to settle for mechanical engineering and committed myself to performing well so that I could pursue a masters in aerospace engineering. By the time I reached the end of the sixth semester in mid-2005, I was well placed to start a career in the core manufacturing sector, in the event I failed to secure admission to a good aerospace programme.

Just when it seemed like I had it all figured out, I started having second thoughts about what I truly wanted to do in the long run. This introspection was partly triggered by my visits to Ramakrishna Math, the writings of Swami Vivekananda, Dr. Arun Shourie's incisive and piercing books[1] and the spike post the elections of May 2004 in the normalised and open hostility directed at specific Indic sub-identities, especially on academic campuses. Had it not been for the writings of Swami Vivekananda and Dr. Shourie, I would have missed the forest for the trees since it was evident that the hostility, while on the face of it, was directed at specific Indic sub-identities in the name of societal reparation, it was, in reality, meant to weaken the larger Indic civilisational edifice. Systematic isolation, ostracisation and acculturation of one Indic strand at a time seemed to be at play. It became clearer with each passing day that this hostility had the previously tacit but increasingly overt support of extra-civilisational, specifically colonial and non-Indic systems that stood to benefit from this motivated internecine tussle.

Thanks to my interactions with better informed people who were civilisationally rooted and had worked on the ground, I gradually came to